

Alytes obstetricans

Midwife toad



Location W. and C. Europe

Length 1¼–2 in (3–5 cm)
Habit Mostly terrestrial
Breeding season Spring and summer
Status Least concern



The midwife toad is notable for its highly unusual method of breeding. The female lays large, yolk-filled eggs in strings, which are transferred to the

male during mating. The male then wraps these strings of eggs around his legs, sometimes carrying 2 strings laid by different females. Once the eggs are ready to hatch, the male deposits them in ponds and pools. This toad is small and plump, with short legs and sandy, pale brown, or gray skin, with darker spots. It inhabits woodland, gardens, drystone walls, sand dunes, and rock slides, hiding in crevices in winter and during dry periods. Active at night, it feeds on invertebrates. Males attract females by calling from a crevice or burrow, making a distinctive, high-pitched “poo-poo” sound.

*Pelobates fuscus*

Common spadefoot toad



Location C. and E. Europe, W. Asia

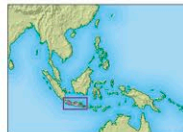
Length 1½–3¼ in (4–8 cm)
Habit Mostly terrestrial
Breeding season Spring
Status Least concern



This plump, variable toad has a pale “spade” on each hind foot, enabling it to dig backward into the soil. It lives in sand dunes, and in cultivated areas, preying on insects and other invertebrates. When threatened, it squeals, inflates its body, and raises itself up to appear larger. It emits a garliclike odor, possibly to deter predators.

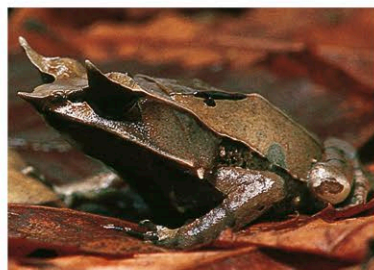
*Megophrys montana*

Asian spadefoot



Location S.E. Asia

Length 2¾–5½ in (7–14 cm)
Habit Mostly terrestrial
Breeding season Rainy season
Status Least concern



This tropical toad is one of the world's most effectively camouflaged amphibians. It lives on the forest floor, mimicking dead leaves. Its brown color and its shape are remarkably leaflike, with a sharp snout, pointed “horns” over its eyes, and folds of skin that look like leaf edges. Female Asian spadefoot toads lay their eggs under rocks in streams. After hatching, the tadpoles hang vertically from the water's surface, and feed on very small organisms using their large, umbrella-shaped mouths.

Rhinophrynus dorsalis

Mexican burrowing toad



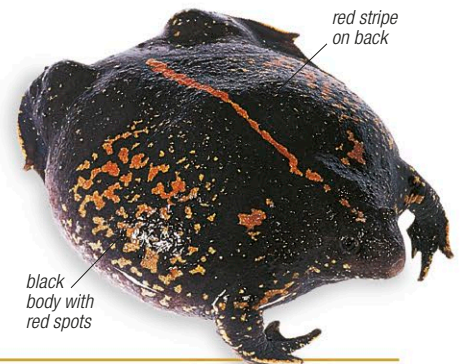
Location S. USA to Central America

Length 2¼–3¼ in (6–8 cm)
Habit Terrestrial/Burrowing
Breeding season Rainy season
Status Least concern



With its bloated body, pointed snout, and small legs, this unusual-looking toad is adapted to a life spent underground. It lives in low-lying regions where soft soil

makes it easy to burrow, emerging only after heavy rain. Adults breed in ponds, and the males have internal vocal sacs that they use to call to females. After the eggs hatch, the tadpoles feed by filtering food from the water, using barbels around their mouths.

*Scaphiopus couchii*

Couch's spadefoot



Location S. USA, Mexico

Length 2¼–3½ in (5.5–9 cm)
Habit Mostly terrestrial
Breeding season Spring and summer
Status Least concern



large eyes with vertical pupils



One of 7 similar species, all from North America, this yellow or yellowish green toad, with darker mottling, is a classic example of an amphibian that survives drought by burrowing underground. Like its relatives, it has spadelike black ridges on its hind feet, which it uses to dig its way 3¼ ft (1 m) or more into loose, sandy soil. Once below ground, it encases its body in a watertight cocoon made by shedding several layers of skin, and then remains dormant, waiting for rain. When rain does fall—sometimes many months later—the cocoon breaks down, and this toad makes its way to the surface to breed.

Pelodytes punctatus

Parsley frog



Location W. and S.W. Europe

Length 1¼–2 in (3–5 cm)
Habit Mostly terrestrial
Breeding season Spring
Status Least concern



The small, agile parsley frog lives in damp, vegetated habitats near ponds. It has an unusual method of climbing, which involves clinging onto vertical surfaces such as trees, rocks, and walls, using its belly as a kind of suction pad. Its name derives from the green flecks on its pale skin that resemble chopped

parsley. Like most frogs, it is active at night, spends winter and dry spells buried underground, and feeds on insects and other invertebrates. During the breeding season, males call out from underwater to attract females, who call back. Females lay their eggs in broad strips in ponds. The tadpoles sometimes grow to be larger than the adult frogs.

